The Lonely Soldier

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Teen And Up Audiences

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Hordak (She-Ra)

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by ManInTheBlueSuit

Summary

In the early days of the war , Hordak takes a desperate gamble to create a new type of soldier, one that can withstand any punishment, recover from any wound. But life and death are fundamental constants that should not be treated lightly, and recovering from any grievous injury requires nutrition - and these new soldiers have a hunger that is not easily sated.

The Etherian Horde had been the nightmares of countless fallen soldiers, and untold scores of innocent civilians. Even before the sky broke open and the stars returned, even before the She-Ra had revealed herself, even before the fall of King Micah and the first Princess Alliance, it had been a nightmare of unfathomable darkness.

You see, there were few around who still remembered the early days of the Horde, back when their leader was easily viewable, back when the Scorpioni Kingdom had barely fallen. Back before the city of metal and pain had earned itself the name "the Fight Zone." Anyone who spoke of those days did so with scorn, with disbelief. That they couldn't have possibly foreseen a single stranger with a band of scavengers and thugs in his employ could have possibly become a tyrant that would bring Etheria to its knees.

When asked about the Scorpioni Kingdom, the elders would shrug, or look away in shame. The fall of a single kingdom had been enough to alarm them, true, but only to guarding their borders, to reinforcing their armies. They did not know then what would follow.

In the weeks and months that had come after the fall of the Scorpioni, the other kingdoms were still acting independently. Coordination was not a key tactic, nor deeply practiced. Truthfully, it was barely even a thought to most of the kingdoms. They were not warriors, hardly any standing armies. Towns had guards for protections against beasts, capitals has guards for ceremonial purposes, and the few trained contingents that existed were used to hunting bandits, not fighting armies. There had been no need of war on Etheria since the time of the First Ones, and no kingdom or group had any reasons to attempt otherwise, not when resources were freely shared. The emergence of a new power, especially one unfamiliar to them, only caused their reactions to be slower, less coherent. But, when the trained soldiers had trained soldiers themselves, and the armies were willing to take the fight back to the fledgling empire, the response was...unforeseeable.

The tanks and guns and weaponry and defences that would one day be considered inherently commonplace across the planet did not spring up overnight. Locating, mining, and refining the raw materials alone took months, and impurities threatened the work. The magically infused atmosphere produced unique feedback amongst the weapons being produced with the precious materials. Some would misfire, damaging the troops wielding them. Others would behave erratically, losing aim, or overpowering defences at random. It made fighting the growing tides of enemies a difficult proposition at the best of times. Word had it that the elusive leader, Hordak, had personally constructed and refined each of the original weapons that had been used in conquering the ruling family of the Crimson Waste and setting up base in their native caldera. Now, he was attempting to automate the process, to allow hundreds of these weapons to be created and dispensed to troops that would flock to such a cause of unrivalled power. It was the reason that the other kingdoms chose to ultimately unite in the first Alliance.

The trigger point for the entire shift was a straightforward battle, at first. A fleet of red wings had spread themselves across a cluster of towns between the caldera and the coast, seeking to establish a secure path to the ocean. It had been easy to overrun each village, crushing the pitiful resistance the guards put up, and breaking the will of any dissidents. Those who couldn't flee in time were forced into servitude, one after the other. It was an easy conquest...until the pirates arrived.

King Triton had given an offer to the buccaneers who regularly fed on the wealth of the Salenian civilian populations: free reign to attack these invaders in exchange for reduction of sentences for any crimes caused against his kingdom. Providing they harmed no innocents, he would uphold his end of the bargain.

The first wave was an unmitigated slaughter. Soldier and commander fell alike, unable to decipher tactics when there were none to be found. If a pirate saw an emblem, they attacked. Sometimes swarming, sometimes shooting, sometimes simply

crowding them into buildings to be set ablaze and then waiting outside.

The solution was a simple as it was practical - an increase in numbers to match force with force. This approach held, for a time. Until the spark of change happened upon them.

It was a cold village, on the far side of the caldera from the oceangoing kingdom of Salenias, something they had assumed would keep them safe. The last action they had expected was to see pirates leaping from fishing vessels with furs draped around their shoulders, and flaming torches in their hands.

What they couldn't have expected was the sudden arrival of soldiers from the Kingdom of Snows to arrive on another flank, hemming in with an unplanned pincer manoeuvre that cut off a third of their forces from the main bulk. That third were the lucky ones, able to escape and report the losses. But it would have been better if they had fought to the death.

With that one victory over a small handful of tiny settlements, the pirates and the soldiers realised that they had no quarrel with each other, but plenty to gain from working together. Word reached their respective leaders, an allyship was struck, and diplomatic overtures dispatched to the other kingdoms.

Of them all, only Mystacor stood aside, knowing their magic held too much power to be used in warfare. But the remaining kingdoms were growing wise to the benefits of cooperation, of an alliance. It took time, learning to move in concert with each other, but they began small - asking who would be in an area to provide backup, dispatching resources and sharing reports.

Losses mounting on multiple fronts, and word of growing unrest amongst the troops under his command, Hordak was forced to take a dreadful gamble - one that would change the course of the war, and the fate of the entire universe.

Rumours had long swirled around the regenerative abilities of the lizard folk. How they healed quicker than average, that some could even grow back their tails if they lost them. Fresh wounds only , but strong regenerative abilities. Cloning a body was a simple matter, requiring only a stable DNA strand and a healthy growth medium. The atmosphere might have been affecting the technology under his employ, but biology in a sealed environment was significantly easier.

Hordak took samples from those who had boasted recovery from the deadliest, most severe wounds, and searched their genomes for commonalities. His immediate concern was for the stability of the force he had built, but maybe this was also the first step towards a cure for his own flaw.

The research took weeks, days that became increasingly dire on the war front as the kingdoms continued to harmonise, growing more adept at working together. It was only when the ranking of ficers, those he called his Force Captains'were on the verge of outright rebellion that he revealed what he had been working on;a cure for all their wounds.

It wouldn't be perfect. Lost limbs would not come back, and any head wounds would not be easily recovered from, but, barring loss of limb or life, it would rewrite their genetic code to heal from any wound or injury . Initial results were below their level of understanding, but they could understand the view from sample dishes. How small organisms appeared to be damaged, only to regrow within minutes. To see them torn, and then mended again provided a spark of renewal in the soldiers as well. Hordak was capable of diverting that attention back to the battlefield, but it was only a matter of time before the weapons he had so freely given returned to his neck.

Half a year after the first shared effort between the Snows and the Salenians, the inevitable happened - there was a break in the lines. A combined front between Bright Moon, Salenias, and Dryl came closer to reaching the caldera than any since it had fallen. They thought themselves a success.

They did not know they were the example.

A squadron had been sent to meet them. They cut it down. It was war, afterall. But they missed one, a single soldier that reared up and took down two of their own before they realised what had happened and could kill it with a blade to their heart.

Shaken, but unperturbed, they made to tend to their wounded.

The soldier struck again.

It was the same one, the bloody streaks from the centre of the breastplate a unique marking. It fell another two soldiers, wounding a third before it was speared in the back, pinning it to the ground. A bloody death rattle finally confirmed their success, at a high cost.

Until the soldier started moving again, standing upright with the spear still emerged from their stomach.

By the time the reinforcements arrived, the joint expedition was in complete disarray, scattered and fleeing. It was light work to dispatch of the cowards, and their corpses were lit where they lay.

Hordak himself congratulated the soldier, the first volunteer for the experiment.

Soon enough, an entire squad volunteered themselves as test subjects. It took the entire stock that he had cultivated, but they quick assimilated the changes, heading to the front lines. The allied kingdoms quickly came to fear this squad, knowing to flee from them on sight. They tried to fight, to pin the monsters down, but nothing worked permanently. Even impaling them to buildings had failed - they simply walked forward until the grounding mechanisms slipped through their bodies and they could turn their fury on the impalers.

The kingdoms weren't the only ones to notice the changes in the battlefield.

A quartermaster by the name of Keb was in charge of ensuring the squadron had everything they needed. Fresh weaponry, new armour, anything they needed. All he had to do was report to Hordak, and it would be granted. "They continue to grow stronger, and faster, as time goes on." Keb reported, taking the sour grunt as approval. "They're also requesting more food."

"Grant them double rations," Hordak growled, dismissing the concern. "They have earned the nutrition for their efforts."

That was another oddity that Keb had noticed. Lord Hordak did not call it 'food', only 'nutrition'. "They're already on double rations," He reminded their leader. "And we've had reports that they've been stealing from the other units as well."

"Your role is to ensure they remain fit for duty," Hordak towered over Keb, intimidating in the thick layer of armour he had crafted. "Whatever it takes, you are to provide - they are our greatest weapon."

Keb took that authority and doubled their ration count again. Even when being presented with four times the food, they continued to show signs of nearly ravenous hunger - despite being fed nothing but the brown ration bars.

It had been one year, four months, and twelve days since the first soldier had been seen on the battlefield. The kingdoms allied against the force they now accepted as 'the Horde' were striving to work in concert, to slay these monsters that were swarming against them. Four squadrons now, each as deadly as the last. Hordak had re-cultivated the original strain of the serum; first on the second squadron, then waiting until he had enough to double their ranks with two more.

All four were deployed to the battle of Bone Canyon.

t had gone by another name before that battle. Y ou could still see it on some of the older maps. B t what happened that day forever changed it.

B ght Moon, Dryl, the Snows, and Salenias all sent a contingent. What Salenias lacked in manpower, they made up for with weaponry, and the barbarism of the pirates who had agreed to work alongside the alliance. Rumour was that even a few sorcerers from Mystacor had secreted themselves into the ranks, skirting the issue of non-interference by providing defensive measures where they could.

t was a bloodbath.

Doz ens of soldiers fell as the monsters continued to rise and fight and rise and fight and rise and fight. They had been wounded in previous fights, stitched back together and merged with machine weaponry they used to brutal effect. The battle raged for hours, half the Alliance forces occupied with nothing but those four sqadrons when the change happened. Their movements became increasingly erratic, bestial even. t was a Salenian who struck the first blow , a shining blade carving through muscle and sinew to decapitate one of the beasts. t was an act that went against everything the Alliance stood for, but it was the first time that one of these soldiers dropped and stayed dead.

Word spread, frantic screams to crush the skull, remove the head, that this was the only way these monsters would die.

Perhaps it was the constant cycle of being killed and brought back, or maybe it was the realisation that their survival no longer guaranteed. Some even postulated that the serum they had been inj ected with, the solution that Hordak had cultivated for over a year , had continued to mutate independently of his control. Others said that it was the constant regeneration demanding new sources of nutrition at any cost. Whatever the reason, the outcome was the same;they began to feed. B ing, tearing chunks from their foes. t was no longer possible to tell a difference between the regenerative soldiers and beasts from nightmare stories.

A single, chilling order was declared by the Alliance forces: no quarter. They would not stop, they would not rest, they would simply fight and die until these monsters were defeated.

Two more fell, then a third, as they became increasingly desperate. Half the squads were eliminated no matter how desperately they bit and gnawed.

Once it became clear that the Alliance were going to fight these monstrosities until they extinguished, the creatures turned on the only source of food not attacking them - their own comrades.

Screams and tearing sounded from all sides as the blood-soaked uniforms became indistinguishable from each other. Desperate calls went out over the radio, begging for assistance from commanders, artillery, even Hordak himself. And then the impossible happened: those bitten turned rabid, infected by the same hunger.

There wasn't any hope. It was a slaughter, on both sides. The remaining Horde soldiers were in chaos, unable to tell friend from foe until the bites set in. It was ten minutes of utter chaos that lasted lifetimes before the order came in.

Artillery units were ordered to open fire on the enhanced soldiers. They were deemed beyond saving, and a danger to the Horde.

Alliance and Horde soldiers died alike, united for an insane moment in obliterating these creatures that kept coming back, kept piecing themselves together with bits of decayed flesh still fastening to their jaws as they consumed the bodies falling around them. Blast after blast targeted them, arrows were lit on fire and shot into them from afar. Those they wounded, those they *bit*, sacrificed themselves to hold the creatures in place for even a second, to let another shot impact them, to drag them back towards the death they should have accepted a long time ago.

The result was a bloody pit of broken bodies and torn flesh, still twitching as the unnatural creatures groaned weakly, trying to drag

themselves back together.

Outside the rest of the war, a temporary alliance was struck.

Any bodies, Horde or Rebellion, were thrown into the canyon, a single, massive grave. But they couldn't take the risk that this monstrosity would be contained so easily. The sorcerers from Mystacor that had slipped into the ranks formed a dome over the remains, casting spell after spell through the shield to erase any possible carrier that remain inside. Some soldiers who had been bitten threw themselves into the pyre, screaming that they couldn't stand to become monsters themselves. Few tried to stop them, out of a combination of respect for their sacrifice, and the fear that they might be right.

The remaining forces accepted that too high a cost had already been paid, and let both sides depart uncontested. The Horde accepted that the Rebellion had finally put an end to the abhorrent practice, and the Rebellion gratefully took their word that those had been the only four squads to accept the treatment. Even now, Hordak was ordering a ban on the experiment, erasing the data, and roaring outrage as work towards curing his own affliction was lost in the process.

All four squads were reported destroyed - but nobody encountered the original test subject. He slipped away when word of the battle reported back, and the order of extermination given for the other participants.

They say that he's still out there, lurking on the edge of the worst battlefields. Horde, Rebellion, he doesn't care. All that matters is that he gets to eat. And sometimes, if he finds someone strong enough to have held on when all the others are dead, he'll bite just a bit deeper, just a bit softer, in hope that he won't be alone anymore. That he'll finally have someone like him. That he won't have to be the Lonely Soldier.

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